ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Semiconductor English

Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For semiconductor process engineers, yield engineers, product engineers, equipment engineers, fab supervisors, quality teams, test and packaging teams, foundry coordinators, supply planners, applications engineers, and technical program managers.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Wafer Fabrication Flow and Process Integration
Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Lithography, Reticles, and Critical Dimensions
Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Deposition, Etch, CMP, and Process Windows
Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Metrology, SPC, and Yield Learning
Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

05 Defect Density and Cleanroom Contamination
Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

06 Equipment Uptime, Recipes, and Tool Matching
Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

07 Packaging, Test, and Reliability Qualification
Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Foundry, Tape-Out, PDK, and Capacity Communication
Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | Speak and respond

Give two minutes of preparation. Run the partner exchange, switch roles, and add the follow-up challenge. Observe whether the listener can act on the message.

35-47 minutes | Write for a real reader

Learners write the short message using only case facts. Partners check clarity, certainty, and the requested next step.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, shorten the first conversation and assign writing for follow-up. For 90 minutes, add 15 minutes for a second case and 15 minutes for the final challenge. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Wafer Fabrication Flow and Process Integration

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A new colleague confuses wafer fabrication with packaging. A process overview needs to explain where the current work takes place.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: wafer, fab, process flow, node.

Model response

Wafer fabrication forms devices on the wafer; packaging happens later in the product flow. Our update concerns the fabrication stage. I'll show the relevant process steps before discussing the issue.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.

2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Lithography, Reticles, and Critical Dimensions

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A lithography review reports a critical-dimension shift but does not identify the layer or measurement conditions.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: lithography, photoresist, reticle, critical dimension.

Model response

Which layer and measurement conditions does the shift refer to? Please include the target, observed result, and reference recipe so we can discuss the same comparison.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.

2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Deposition, Etch, CMP, and Process Windows

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A process change improves one measured outcome but has not been checked across the proposed operating range.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: deposition, etch, CMP, process window.

Model response

The result is encouraging at the tested settings. We have not established the wider process window. I'll distinguish the observed improvement from the conditions that still need evaluation.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Metrology, SPC, and Yield Learning

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A pilot lot has 92% yield compared with 90% in a reference lot. The sample sizes and product mix differ.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: metrology, SPC, yield, excursion.

Model response

The pilot's reported yield is two percentage points higher. The lots differ in size and mix, so the comparison needs qualification. I'll show those details alongside the headline result.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Defect Density and Cleanroom Contamination

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A contamination review needs the timing and location of observed particles. The current note says only "cleanroom problem."

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: defect density, particle, cleanroom, contamination control.

Model response

Could you provide the observation time, location, and relevant records? A precise description will help the team investigate without assuming a contamination source before reviewing the evidence.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Equipment Uptime, Recipes, and Tool Matching

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two tools run the same nominal recipe but show different measured results. A team member assumes their performance is interchangeable.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: tool uptime, preventive maintenance, recipe, tool matching.

Model response

The recipe name is the same, but the observed results differ. Let's compare the controlled settings and qualification evidence before describing the tools as matched for this process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

2. C - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Packaging, Test, and Reliability Qualification

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A package passes one reliability test while two planned tests remain open. A customer slide calls qualification complete.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: package, binning, burn-in, qualification.

Model response

One test is complete; two are still open. I'll report the results by test and avoid describing the overall qualification as complete until the responsible team confirms the required evidence.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Foundry, Tape-Out, PDK, and Capacity Communication

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A customer requests an earlier tape-out slot. Design checks are still open, and foundry capacity is limited.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: foundry, tape-out, PDK, capacity allocation.

Model response

We can review the earlier slot, but the open design checks and capacity need confirmation. Could we agree on a decision point that reflects both readiness and the foundry's available schedule?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the if-clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The if-clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.